UX CASE STUDY · SHIPMENT BOOKING JOURNEY

QUOTE TO CHECKOUT

How four courier sites in the UAE take a customer from “how much?” to “book it”, scored against Nielsen’s heuristics, with a ranked fix list and three A/B tests for EMX.

STOPPED BEFORE PAYMENT

LANE Dubai → Abu Dhabi (UAE domestic)	PARCEL 1 box · 2 kg · 30 × 20 × 15 cm
DECLARED VALUE AED 100	AUDIT DATE 29 Oct 2026

customer journey · usability · UX/UI · quotation · booking · checkout · payment · competitor benchmarking · navigation · calls to action · mobile · desktop

1 · THE BRIEF, REFINED

One parcel, four sites, the same questions

The rough idea was “audit the booking flow and compare competitors”. To make that measurable, every site got the identical shipment, the same stop rule, and the same scoring rubric, and every number on this page comes from a script you can rerun.

Research questions

- How many screens and fields stand between a visitor and a price?
- Can a first-time customer book without an account?
- Is the price honest: inclusions, add-ons, delivery date?
- What changes on a phone?

Rules of the walk-through

- Identical lane and parcel on every site
- Dummy shipment data only; no personal data typed
- No accounts created; stop at sign-in walls
- Stop before any payment screen
- Non-essential cookies rejected everywhere

Free stack, no API keys

`Lighthouse 12 CLI` `Playwright Chromium` `DevTools device mode`
`Form-audit snippet` `Node build script` `GitHub Pages`
`GrowthBook (open source)` `Microsoft Clarity`

Lighthouse runs locally against a downloaded Chromium, so there is no PageSpeed quota or key. The last two tools are for running the A/B tests after launch.

2 · BENCHMARK

What it takes to see a price

EMX already wins on two things competitors fail: guest booking and an up-front delivery date. It loses on how easy the quote is to find and on what the price card explains.

MEASURE	EMX CLIENT	ARAMEX COMPETITOR	DHL COMPET
Screens to first price	1	1	3
Inputs shown before price	10	14	18
Inputs I had to fill	4	9	10
Price, 2 kg domestic	AED 25.00 VAT not stated	AED 48.00 AED 73.00 with pre-ticked SHIELD	No quc Get Quc nothing
Delivery date with price	`Sat 31 Oct`	`Service name only (“Overnight”)`	`–`
Guest booking	`Yes`	`No`	`Yes (`
Booking page, mobile perf.	98	71	56
Where it ended	Reached sender details (wizard step 3 of 5)	Sign-in wall after “Create Shipment Now”	Silent f Get Qu

3 · JOURNEY MAPS

Where each journey ended

Each box is one screen or state. The number is how many inputs it shows. Only EMX let the walk continue past the price without an account.

Price shown · Stopped: personal data · Sign-in wall · Failed · Not reached

EMX

6 STATES · 24 INPUTS SEEN

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	STEP 4
Homepage “Get Rates & Send Shipment” tile **0 inputs**	**Shipment details** Emirates, type, weight, value, box size **10 inputs**	**Service type** Express · AED 25.00 · by Sat 31 Oct **1 input**	**Sender details** Pickup slot, name, email, phones, map pin **13 inputs**

STEP 5	STEP 6
Receiver details Not entered –	**Review & confirm** Payment follows –

Aramex

4 STATES · 16 INPUTS SEEN

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	STEP 4
Homepage Hero is tracking only; Rate Calculator further down **0 inputs**	**Calculate rates** Country, cities, zip codes, value, boxes, weight, L × W × H **14 inputs**	**Rates (same page)** AED 48.00 + SHIELD AED 25.00 pre-ticked **2 inputs**	**Create shipment** Redirects to login.aramex.com –

DHL Express

5 STATES · 20 INPUTS SEEN

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	STEP 4
Homepage widget “Get a Rate and Time Quote” tab **2 inputs**	**From / To** Country, address, city, province × 2 **10 inputs**	**Documents or packages** With a plain-language explainer **2 inputs**	**Package details** Packaging, quantity, weight, L × W × H **6 inputs**

STEP 5
Get Quote No rates, no message –

FedEx

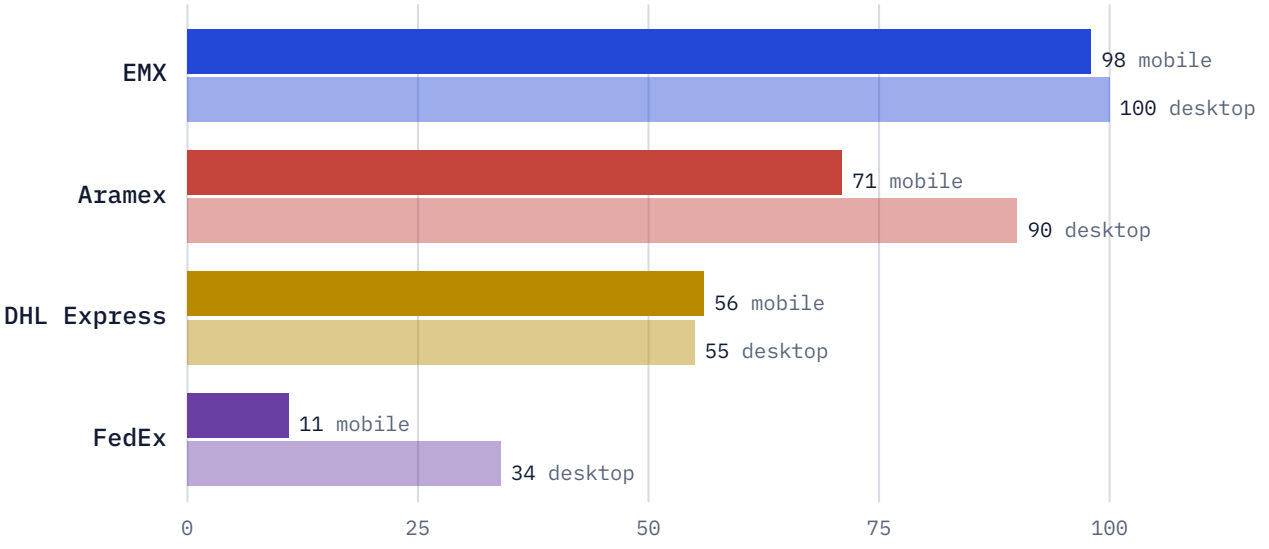
4 STATES · 15 INPUTS SEEN

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	STEP 4
Rate tool	**Shipment details**	**Rates**	**Choose rate**
Two smart address fields (Google Places)	Revealed after addresses: packaging, weight, dims, date	AED 100.72 · arrives “--”	Redirects to secure-login
`2 inputs`	`10 inputs`	`3 inputs`	—

4 · MOBILE VS DESKTOP

Lighthouse, then a thumb test

EMX's booking page is the fastest page in the study. Its homepage, where most journeys start, is one of the slowest. Scores are Lighthouse 12 lab runs (mobile uses simulated 4G and a 4× CPU slowdown).



SITE	DEVICE	PERF.	A11Y	LCP	CLS	MB
EMX	mobile	98	96	1.5 s	0.02	0.7
	desktop	100	96	0.4 s	0.01	0.7
Aramex	mobile	71	87	3.2 s	0.06	6.3
	desktop	90	87	1.2 s	0.01	6.5
DHL Express	mobile	56	96	14.2 s	0.07	2.1
	desktop	55	86	4.1 s	0.27	6.9
FedEx	mobile	11	87	27.0 s	0.29	4.3
	desktop	34	85	7.5 s	0.15	4.1

Manual checks at 375 px

SITE	REDIRECT ON PHONE	INPUT TEXT	FIRST INPUT
EMX	None	16 px	~720 px
Aramex	None	9 of 11 at 14 px	~600 px
DHL Express	To country/language picker	16 px	Picker first
FedEx	None	16 px	~340 px

5 · HEURISTIC EVALUATION

34 issues, rated on Nielsen's scale

Each cell shows how many issues a site has under one heuristic, shaded by the worst severity among them (1 cosmetic, 2 minor, 3 major, 4 catastrophe). Select a cell or use the filters to read the issues behind it.

	H1 Visibility of	H2 Match with	H3 User control	H4 Consistency and	H5 Error prevention	H6 Recognition over	H7 Flexibility and	H8 Aesthetic and	H9 Error recognition	H10 Help and
EMX	2	1	·	3	·	1	2	3	·	·
Aramex	2	1	2	1	1	·	2	2	1	·
DHL Express	2	1	1	·	2	·	1	1	1	·
FedEx	2	·	2	2	·	·	·	1	·	·

Showing 34 of 34

DHL-01
4 Catastrophe

Get Quote returns no rates and no message

Two attempts on the UAE domestic lane. The page stays put; the console shows a 404 from the address lookup.

DHL Express
H1 + H9 Visibility of system status / Error recognition and recovery
Get Quote · Desktop

ARX-01
3 Major

SHIELD protection is pre-ticked and raises the total by 52%

Base AED 48.00 + SHIELD AED 25.00 checked by default = AED 73.00.

Aramex
H3 User control and freedom
Rates · Both

ARX-02
3 Major

Length, width and height look optional, are required, and fail off-screen

Labels have no asterisk. On submit the page scrolls to the top and the three errors render out of view.

Aramex
H5 + H9 Error prevention / Error recognition and recovery
Calculate rates · Both

ARX-03
3 Major

No guest booking: sign-in wall after the quote

“Create Shipment Now” redirects to login.aramex.com, which pre-lists two common login errors.

Aramex
H3 + H7 User control and freedom / Flexibility and efficiency
Create shipment · Both

DHL-02
3 Major

Pre-filled weight turns “2” into 0.52 kg

Choosing “My Own Package” fills 0.5 kg; typing appends to it with no warning.

DHL Express
H5 Error prevention
Package details · Both

DHL-03
3 Major

Phones are sent to a country and language picker first

The /ae/en quote link redirects to /index/en/mobile.html: “Select Country/Territory”, “Select Language”, Next.

DHL Express
H3 + H7 User control and freedom / Flexibility and efficiency
Homepage widget · Mobile

EMX-01
3 Major

“Send a Shipment” button opens the Card Services page

Homepage link href is /CardServicesSolutions while the tile next to it points to products.emx.ae/sendshipment.

EMX
H4 Consistency and standards
Homepage · Both

EMX-08
3 Major

Homepage, the way into booking, is slow and jumpy on phones

Lighthouse mobile: Performance 29, LCP 13.8 s, CLS 0.38, 4.3 MB transferred.

EMX
H1 Visibility of system status
Homepage · Mobile

FDX-01
3 Major

Rate shows no delivery date

“Arrives on --” and “Delivered by --” next to AED 100.72.

FedEx
H1 Visibility of system status
Rates · Both

FDX-02
3 Major

No guest booking: choosing a rate opens sign-in

Clicking the price goes to /secure-login/en-ae.

FedEx
H3 User control and freedom
Choose rate · Both

FDX-06
3 Major

Rate page is the slowest page audited

Lighthouse mobile: Performance 11, LCP 27.0 s, TBT 2.8 s. Homepage transfers ~20 MB.

FedEx
H1 Visibility of system status
Rate tool · Mobile

ARX-04
2 Minor

UAE site does not preselect UAE and asks for zip codes

Domestic tab starts at “Select country” (list opens at Afghanistan). Zip Code shows as required until a country is set; the UAE has no postcodes.

Aramex
H2 Match with the real world
Calculate rates · Both

ARX-06
2 Minor

Small inputs zoom the page on iPhone; CTA is two screens down

9 of 11 inputs use 14 px text (iOS zooms below 16 px). Get Rates sits ~1,600 px down behind a decorative image.

Aramex
H7 + H8 Flexibility and efficiency / Aesthetic and minimalist design
Calculate rates · Mobile

ARX-07
2 Minor

Homepage hero is tracking only

No quote or ship CTA above the fold; Rate Calculator is a lower section card.

Aramex
H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design
Homepage · Both

ARX-08
2 Minor

Slow homepage on mobile

Lighthouse mobile: Performance 39, LCP 9.4 s, Best Practices 50.

Aramex
H1 Visibility of system status
Homepage · Mobile

ARX-09
2 Minor

Country list opened empty on first load

Typing found no options until the page was reloaded. Observed once.

Aramex
H1 Visibility of system status
Calculate rates · Desktop

DHL-04
2 Minor

UAE not preset; emirate is called “Province”

Country starts empty on the UAE site; the homepage widget truncates the label to “Countr…”.

DHL Express
H2 Match with the real world
From / To · Both

DHL-05
2 Minor

Legal liability paragraph dominates the package step

A 60-word GCAA warning sits above the inputs before any price is shown.

DHL Express
H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design
Package details · Both

DHL-06
2 Minor

Heavy, shifting booking page

Lighthouse: mobile LCP 14.2 s; desktop CLS 0.27 and 6.9 MB transferred.

DHL Express
H1 Visibility of system status
Homepage widget · Both

DHL-07
2 Minor

Wrong country committed when the suggestion list closed

Destination silently became “Afghanistan”; only a red border signalled it. Observed once.

DHL Express
H5 Error prevention
From / To · Desktop

EMX-02
2 Minor

Two different 5-step models on the same screen

Stepper: Shipment Details → Service Type → Sender → Receiver → Review. Side panel: Origin & Destination → Describe → Price → Sender & Receiver → Booking.

EMX
H4 Consistency and standards
Shipment details · Desktop

EMX-03
2 Minor

Price card does not say what AED 25.00 includes

No VAT, pickup or insurance statement on the card. Inclusions sit behind “Details & Benefits”. Aramex states “Price including taxes”.

EMX
H1 + H2 Visibility of system status / Match with the real world
Service type · Both

EMX-04
2 Minor

Phone code list shows ~240 bare dial codes with no country names

Options read “+93, +358, +355 …” in an unsorted order. Repeated for the alternate number.

EMX
H6 Recognition over recall
Sender details · Both

EMX-05
2 Minor

Weight, value and dimensions open the full text keyboard

Inputs are type="text" with no inputmode, so phones show letters instead of a number pad.

EMX
H7 Flexibility and efficiency
Shipment details · Mobile

EMX-06
2 Minor

Name and email fields cannot be autofilled

first_name, last_name and email_address have no autocomplete tokens.

EMX
H7 Flexibility and efficiency
Sender details · Both

EMX-07
2 Minor

Emirate pickers and Shipment Value have no programmatic label

react-select inputs and the value field expose no label or aria-label to screen readers.

EMX
H4 Consistency and standards
Shipment details · Both

EMX-10
2 Minor

Quote is a secondary tile; the hero leads with tracking

Hero offers Track; “Get Rates” and “Send Shipment” sit in a tile row below.

EMX
H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design
Homepage · Both

FDX-03
2 Minor

Account promo sits between the form and the rates

“Sign up now and save up to 55%” banner with OPEN AN ACCOUNT pushes rates below the fold.

FedEx
H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design
Rates · Both

FDX-04
2 Minor

Pickup is pre-ticked with no price impact shown

“I want this shipment picked up” is checked by default.

FedEx
H3 User control and freedom
Rates · Both

FDX-07
2 Minor

L × W × H inputs share one label

The three dimension inputs have no individual accessible names.

FedEx
H4 Consistency and standards
Shipment details · Both

ARX-05
1 Cosmetic

“Send a Shipment” links go to two different URLs

/ship/send-shipments in the menu, /ship/send-a-shipment in the page body.

Aramex
H4 Consistency and standards
Homepage · Both

EMX-09
1 Cosmetic

Domestic / International cards fill the first phone screen

At 375 px the first input starts about 720 px down.

EMX
H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design
Shipment details · Mobile

EMX-11
1 Cosmetic

Booking footer reads “© 2024”

Stale year on a payment journey weakens trust.

EMX
H8 Aesthetic and minimalist design
All steps · Both

FDX-05

1 Cosmetic

Raw translation key exposed

Page text includes “loadingIndicator.loadingComplete”.

FedEx

H4 Consistency and standards

Rate tool · Both

6 · WORTH COPYING

What each site does well

EMX

- Guest booking with no account
- Box-size presets fill L × W × H for you
- Booking page is the fastest of the four (Lighthouse 98 mobile)
- Shows an estimated delivery date with the price
- Stepper collapses to “1 of 5” on mobile

Aramex

- Price shown tax-inclusive with the tax amount
- Live “total chargeable weight” as you type
- Zip fields switch off once UAE is chosen
- “Most popular” label helps the choice

DHL Express

- Says “No account needed – pay with a credit card” up front
- Explains documents vs packages where you choose
- Links prohibited items for the lane
- Homepage accessibility 100 in Lighthouse

FedEx

- Fewest fields to a price (3 filled)
- One smart address field replaces country/city/zip
- Metric units default on the UAE site
- Progressive disclosure keeps the first screen short

7 · RECOMMENDATIONS FOR EMX

Ranked by impact over effort

Impact and effort are scored 1–5. Rank is impact ÷ effort, with impact breaking ties. Quick wins are impact 3+ for effort 2 or less.

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1 **Repoint “Send a Shipment” to the booking flow**

One-line link fix on the homepage. Today it sends booking intent to Card Services.

`Fixes EMX-01`

Impact
Effort
QUICK WIN

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2 **Make guest booking and “no pre-ticked extras” a stated promise**

Aramex and FedEx force sign-in and pre-tick extras. Say “No account needed” on the price card and keep add-ons opt-in.

`Fixes ARX-01, ARX-03, FDX-02`

Impact
Effort
QUICK WIN

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3 **Mobile input hygiene pass**

inputmode="decimal" on numbers, autocomplete tokens on name/email/tel, labels on custom selects.

`Fixes EMX-05, EMX-06, EMX-07`

Impact
Effort
QUICK WIN

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4 **Price card that answers “what am I paying for?”**

“AED 25.00 incl. VAT · pickup included · delivered by Sat 31 Oct”, with the main inclusions visible, not behind a link.

`Fixes EMX-03`

Impact
Effort
QUICK WIN

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5 **One step model**

Rename the side-panel steps to match the stepper, or remove the panel once the form starts.

`Fixes EMX-02`

Impact
Effort
FILL-IN

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6 **Quote starter in the homepage hero**

From emirate, To emirate, weight. Carry the values into step 1 of the wizard.

`Fixes EMX-10`

Impact
Effort
BIG BET

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7 **Searchable country picker for phone codes**

Default +971 with flag and country name; search by name or code.

`Fixes EMX-04`

Impact
Effort
QUICK WIN

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8 **Compact mobile start**

Swap the two large cards for a segmented Domestic | International control and add a sticky Calculate bar.

`Fixes EMX-09`

Impact
Effort
QUICK WIN

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9 **Homepage mobile speed budget**

Resize and compress the hero, set image dimensions, defer third-party scripts. Target LCP < 2.5 s and CLS < 0.1.

`Fixes EMX-08`

Impact
Effort
BIG BET

10 Save or share this quote

Let undecided users email the quote to themselves or copy a link that restores it.

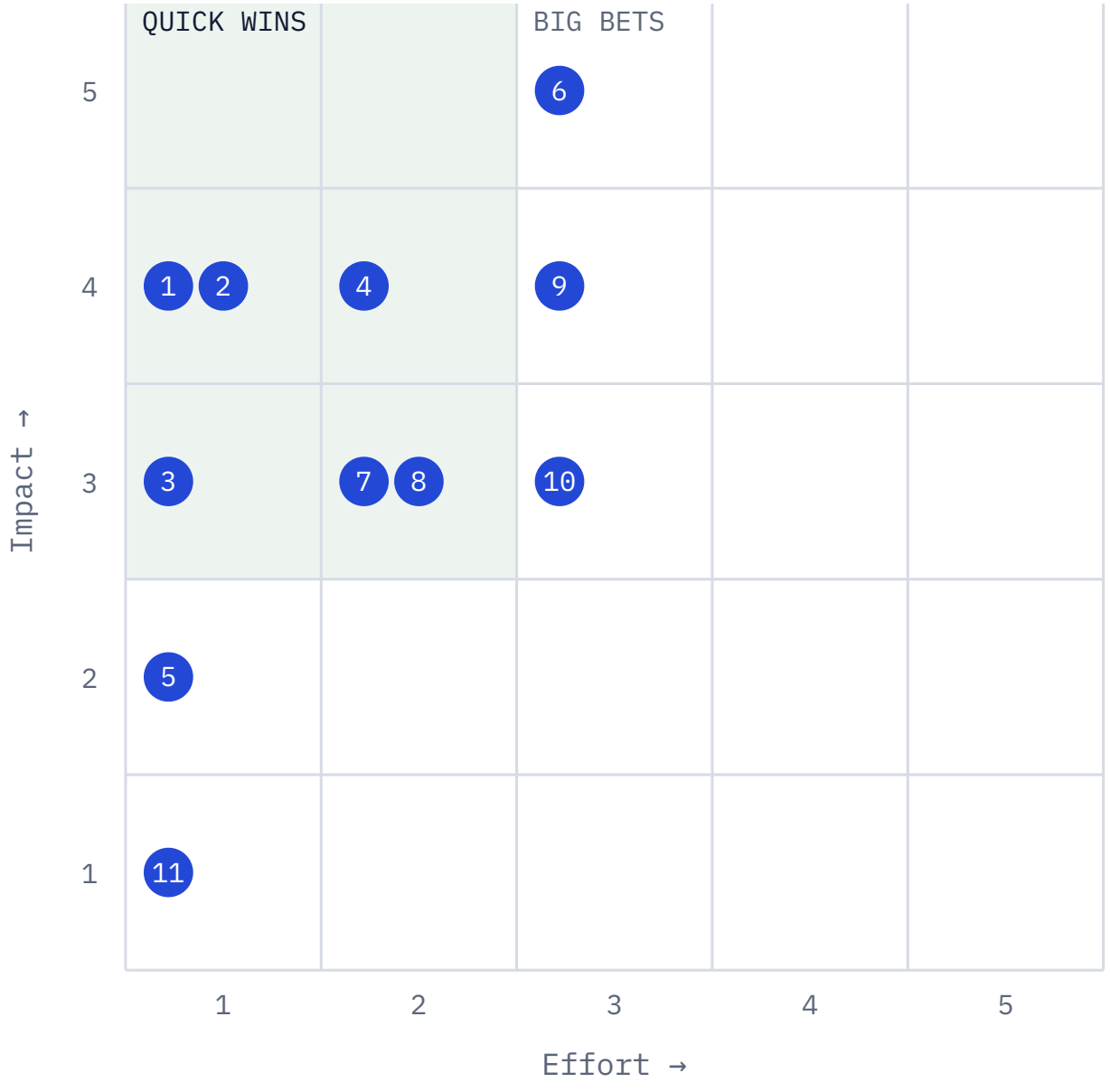
Impact
Effort
BIG BET

11 Refresh footer year and stale copy

Small trust signal on a payment journey.

Fixes EMX-11

Impact
Effort
FILL-IN



8 · EXPERIMENTS

Three A/B tests to run first

Baselines are planning assumptions to replace with EMX analytics. The calculator sizes a two-sided test at 95% confidence and 80% power.

T1

Quote starter in the hero

HYPOTHESIS

Putting From, To and weight in the homepage hero will raise quote starts, because booking intent no longer has to find a secondary tile.

CONTROL

Current hero: tracking field, quote as a tile below

VARIANT

Hero with three fields and a “Get price” button that deep-links into step 1 with values filled

PRIMARY METRIC

Sessions that reach the price step ÷ homepage sessions

SECONDARY

Bookings submitted · Time from landing to price

GUARDRAILS

Tracking searches per session · Homepage bounce rate

17,943 users per arm · 35,886 total
≈ 18 days at 2,000/day

T2

Transparent price card

HYPOTHESIS

Stating VAT, pickup and the delivery date on the card, plus “No account needed”, will move more people from price to sender details.

CONTROL

“Express Service · Estimated delivery · AED 25.00 · Details & Benefits”

VARIANT

“AED 25.00 incl. VAT · Pickup included · Delivered by Sat 31 Oct · No account needed”

PRIMARY METRIC

Service step → Sender step progression

SECONDARY

Review-step completion · Clicks on Details & Benefits

GUARDRAILS

Support contacts about price · Refund requests

5,104 users per arm · 10,208 total
≈ 6 days at 2,000/day (run at least 14 days to cover two weekly cycles)

T3

Mobile form ergonomics

HYPOTHESIS

A compact type toggle, number keypads and a sticky Calculate bar will cut time to price on phones and lift completion.

CONTROL

Current mobile step 1

VARIANT

Segmented Domestic | International, inputmode=decimal, sticky Calculate bar

PRIMARY METRIC

Mobile step-1 completion rate

SECONDARY

Median time to first price · Field error rate

GUARDRAILS

Wrong-weight corrections at review · Desktop completion (unchanged)

4,635 users per arm · 9,270 total
≈ 5 days at 2,000/day (run at least 14 days to cover two weekly cycles)

9 · METHOD AND LIMITS

How to reproduce this

Process

1. Walk each quote flow by hand on desktop, counting visible inputs per screen with a form-audit snippet.
2. Repeat the first screens at 375 px: redirects, input text size, CTA position.
3. Run Lighthouse mobile and desktop on each homepage and booking entry page.
4. Log every issue with evidence, tag one or two heuristics, rate severity 1–4.
5. Score fixes for impact and effort; turn the three biggest unknowns into A/B tests.

Limits

- One evaluator, one lane, one session on 2026-10-29. Sites change; rerun before quoting numbers.
- Heuristic review finds likely problems. It does not replace testing with real customers.
- Lighthouse lab scores vary run to run by a few points.
- DHL’s failure may be lane-specific; it was retried twice.

Commands

```
npm install
npx playwright install chromium
CHROME_PATH=…/Chromium npm run lighthouse
npm run build      # writes dist/index.html
npm run pdf        # writes dist/quote-to-checkout.pdf
```

Data lives in `data/audit.json` and `results/lighthouse.json`. Edit the JSON, rebuild, and every table, chart and ranking on this page updates.

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